CHAPTER CHECKS BY READ FRANCE

Macbeth

by William Shakespeare · 5 checks · 40 questions · answer key, rationale and rubrics

How to use these checks

Give a check right after students finish the act or chapters it covers. Each check opens with a one-word reading checkpoint (1 point): an open question on a concrete detail from the middle of the part, whose answer is a single word of the text, the proof-of-reading method of READ FRANCE's Vread app. Then come recall questions on details a summary skips, inference questions, at least one close-reading question on a short quoted line, and one short written answer graded with the rubric below it. Multiple-choice items are worth 1 point; the written answer is worth 2. A check takes 10 to 15 minutes.

Keep this key apart from the student file. Every key comes with the line of the text that proves it, so a disputed answer can be settled with the book open.

These checks are graded by you, on paper or in your LMS. They do not track students and collect no student data. If you want each student's reading checked automatically as they go, the Vread app by READ FRANCE does that, free for readers.

How these checks were made

Octave, the AI assistant of READ FRANCE, wrote the questions from the text alone. A second, independent pass answered every question from the text before reading the key and fixed any doubtful item, and a script checked that every quotation appears word for word in its chapter. Every question also went through a cold-answer gate: someone who had not read the part, holding only a study-guide summary of it, answered each question; any question the summary was enough to answer was rewritten. No teacher has reviewed this edition yet: tell us about any mistake.

The edition

Text used: *Macbeth* by William Shakespeare, Project Gutenberg eBook #1533 (gutenberg.org/ebooks/1533). First published 1623 (First Folio). Questions refer to 5 acts, never to page numbers, so they work with any complete edition.

William Shakespeare died in 1616; the work was first published in 1623 (First Folio), before 1931, so it is in the public domain in the United States. The author died before 1925, so it is also in the public domain in the UK, Canada and the EU. The questions, answers and rubrics are original work © READ FRANCE SAS.

Found a mistake?

Write to octave@vread.fr with the title, check and question number. We correct the file and send the new version to every buyer of the title.

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Act 1 · answer key (10 points)

#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
CP	**harvest**	checkpoint	**When Duncan embraces Banquo at Forres and holds him to his heart, what does Banquo say will be Duncan's own if he grows there?** One word, found word for word in the text; accept any spelling that is clearly the same word. *“There if I grow, The harvest is your own.”*
1	**C**	recall	**Split him open and set his head on the battlements**. The Captain reports that Macbeth cut Macdonwald open "from the nave to the chops" and fixed his head on the battlements; the rebel was neither captured nor allowed to escape. *“Till he unseam'd him from the nave to the chops, And fix'd his head upon our battlements.”*
2	**B**	recall	**Their beards**. Banquo says the witches "should be women" but their beards forbid him to think so; voices, armor and height are never mentioned. *“You should be women, And yet your beards forbid me to interpret That you are so.”*
3	**A**	close	**It echoes the witches' chant before he has ever met them**. In Scene 1 the witches chant "Fair is foul, and foul is fair"; Macbeth unknowingly echoes them in Scene 3 before they speak to him. They have not yet greeted him (D), and Banquo speaks only after this line (C). *“Fair is foul, and foul is fair: Hover through the fog and filthy air.” … “So foul and fair a day I have not seen.”*
4	**D**	inference	**He is not yet used to his new honors**. Banquo covers for Macbeth by comparing new honors to new clothes that fit only with wear, implying he is simply adjusting to his title; he says nothing of fatigue, pity or the witches to Ross and Angus. *“Look, how our partner's rapt.” … “New honours come upon him, Like our strange garments, cleave not to their mould But with the aid of use.”*
5	**B**	inference	**His face shows his troubled thoughts too plainly**. She tells him his face is "as a book where men May read strange matters" and urges him to look innocent and "look up clear": she fears his expression will betray him. Banquo is not mentioned, and Macbeth has the king's leave to go ahead as harbinger. *“Your face, my thane, is as a book where men May read strange matters.” … “look like the innocent flower, But be the serpent under't.” … “Only look up clear; To alter favour ever is to fear.”*
6	**C**	close	**Ambition is his only motive, and it may overreach and fall**. Like a rider who jumps too hard and falls off the far side, Macbeth admits ambition is his only reason and that it may ruin him; right after, he tells his wife he will not go on. *“I have no spur To prick the sides of my intent, but only Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself And falls on th' other” … “We will proceed no further in this business:”*
7	**D**	recall	**He has newly won golden opinions from all sorts of people**. To his wife Macbeth gives only one reason: Duncan has honored him and he has "bought Golden opinions" he wants to enjoy. The kinsman-and-guest argument (A) stays in his soliloquy, and "chance may crown me" (C) is an aside from Scene 3. *“We will proceed no further in this business: He hath honour'd me of late; and I have bought Golden opinions from all sorts of people,”*

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#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
8	2 pts	written	**Prompt.** Reread Lady Macbeth's line below. How does she use the idea of being "a man" to push Macbeth toward the murder? Support your answer with one detail from Scene 7. “When you durst do it, then you were a man” **Model answer.** Lady Macbeth defines manhood as daring to act on what one wants, so Macbeth's hesitation becomes a loss of manhood. She reminds him that he was "a man" when he first proposed the plan and calls him a coward "in thine own esteem" who lets "I dare not" wait upon "I would." Macbeth replies that a true man knows limits ("Who dares do more is none"), but by the end of the scene he is "settled." **2**: Explains that she links manhood to daring or acting on desire, so backing out makes him less of a man or a coward, AND supports it with a relevant detail from Scene 7 (the coward taunt, the cat proverb, the babe image, Macbeth's reply about what becomes a man, or his final "I am settled"). **1**: Says she insults or pressures him but does not explain the link between manhood and daring, OR gives an accurate reading with no supporting detail. **0**: Misreads the line (for example, says she praises his restraint or means only courage in battle) or does not address it. *“When you durst do it, then you were a man; And, to be more than what you were, you would Be so much more the man.” … “And live a coward in thine own esteem, Letting "I dare not" wait upon "I would,"” … “I dare do all that may become a man; Who dares do more is none.” … “I am settled, and bend up Each corporal agent to this terrible feat.”*

Act 2 · answer key (10 points)

#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
CP	**chimneys**	checkpoint	**On the unruly night of Duncan's murder, what does Lennox say were blown down where he and Macduff lay?** One word, found word for word in the text; accept any spelling that is clearly the same word. *“The night has been unruly: where we lay, Our chimneys were blown down and, as they say, Lamentings heard i’ th’ air, strange screams of death, And prophesying, with accents terrible, Of dire combustion and confus’d events, New hatch’d to the woeful time.”*
1	**A**	recall	**A diamond, greeting her as a most kind hostess**. Banquo reports that the King greets Macbeth's wife with a diamond "by the name of most kind hostess." *“This diamond he greets your wife withal, By the name of most kind hostess”*
2	**C**	inference	**He feels cut off from God's blessing by what he has done**. Macbeth dwells on his inability to say "Amen" when he "had most need of blessing": the murder has shut him out from prayer. He says the sleepers went back to sleep, so A and B misread the episode. *“List'ning their fear, I could not say "Amen," When they did say, "God bless us."” … “But wherefore could not I pronounce "Amen"? I had most need of blessing, and "Amen" Stuck in my throat.”*
3	**B**	close	**Her husband's shout makes her fear the grooms woke first**. Macbeth's cry from within ("Who's there?") makes her fear the grooms have woken before the murder is done; she reassures herself that the daggers were laid ready. The knocking (D) comes only after the murder. *“Who's there?—what, ho!” … “Alack! I am afraid they have awak'd, And 'tis not done. Th' attempt and not the deed Confounds us.” … “I laid their daggers ready; He could not miss 'em.”*
4	**D**	recall	**Strike upon the bell**. Macbeth orders that his wife "strike upon the bell"; when it rings he says "The bell invites me" and goes to Duncan. *“Go bid thy mistress, when my drink is ready, She strike upon the bell.” … “I go, and it is done. The bell invites me.”*

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#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
5	**A**	close	**His own blood-stained hands**. The stage direction shows him "Looking on his hands," and he goes on to speak of "these hangman's hands." He is standing with his wife, not in the chambers, so he cannot be looking at the grooms, Donalbain or Duncan. *“This is a sorry sight. [Looking on his hands.]” … “As they had seen me with these hangman's hands.”*
6	**C**	recall	**Colmekill**. Macduff tells Ross the body went to Colmekill, where earlier kings are buried. Scone is where Macbeth is crowned; Saint Colme's Inch is where the Norwegians paid in Act 1. *“Carried to Colmekill, The sacred storehouse of his predecessors, And guardian of their bones.”*
7	**B**	inference	**He thinks the news too terrible for a woman to hear**. Macduff calls her "gentle lady" and says the news would "murder" a woman's ear: he wants to spare her, which is ironic since she planned the killing. He shows no suspicion of her, and he tells Banquo the news at once. *“O gentle lady, 'Tis not for you to hear what I can speak: The repetition, in a woman's ear, Would murder as it fell.”*
8	2 pts	written	**Prompt.** Reread Lady Macbeth's line below. How does it answer what Macbeth said about his bloody hand while she was away? Support your answer with his image from Scene 2. “A little water clears us of this deed: How easy is it then!” **Model answer.** Lady Macbeth treats the blood as a practical problem that "a little water" will solve. Moments before, alone, Macbeth asked whether "all great Neptune's ocean" could wash the blood from his hand and answered that his hand would rather turn "the multitudinous seas" red. Her "little water" shrinks his ocean: he feels guilt no ocean can clean, while she sees only a stain to wash off. **2**: Contrasts her view (the blood and the deed wash off easily) with his (no water can clean it) AND cites Macbeth's specific image: Neptune's ocean that cannot wash his hand, or his hand turning the seas red ("incarnadine," "making the green one red"). **1**: Explains that she downplays the guilt or contrasts it with his guilt in general terms, without his ocean or seas image. **0**: Misreads the line (for example, says she feels guilty or afraid) or does not address it. *“Will all great Neptune's ocean wash this blood Clean from my hand? No, this my hand will rather The multitudinous seas incarnadine, Making the green one red.” … “My hands are of your color, but I shame To wear a heart so white.” … “A little water clears us of this deed: How easy is it then!”*

Act 3 · answer key (10 points)

#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
CP	**twenty**	checkpoint	**At the banquet, how many trenched gashes does the First Murderer tell Macbeth that Banquo has on his head as he lies in a ditch?** One word, found word for word in the text; accept any spelling that is clearly the same word. *“Safe in a ditch he bides, With twenty trenched gashes on his head; The least a death to nature.”*
1	**A**	recall	**Seven at night**. Macbeth frees his court "Till seven at night" so he can keep himself alone until supper, the hour Banquo must be back for the feast. *“Let every man be master of his time Till seven at night;”*
2	**D**	inference	**He must keep the love of friends he shares with Banquo**. Macbeth needs the goodwill of "certain friends that are both his and mine" and must be seen to mourn Banquo, so the killing has to be hidden. He mentions no law, army or warning from the witches. *“yet I must not, For certain friends that are both his and mine, Whose loves I may not drop, but wail his fall Who I myself struck down:”*

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#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
3	**C**	recall	**Everyone walks the last mile to the palace gate**. The Third Murderer explains that the horses are taken round while Banquo, like all men, walks the last mile to the palace gate. *“His horses go about.” … “Almost a mile; but he does usually, So all men do, from hence to the palace gate Make it their walk.”*
4	**B**	close	**The danger to them is wounded but alive and can still strike**. The snake will heal ("close, and be herself") and bite again; Macbeth means that threats such as Banquo and Fleance are still alive. *“She'll close, and be herself; whilst our poor malice Remains in danger of her former tooth.” … “Thou know'st that Banquo, and his Fleance, lives.”*
5	**B**	recall	**That it will rain tonight**. Banquo remarks, "It will be rain tonight," and the First Murderer answers "Let it come down" as he attacks. *“It will be rain tonight.” … “Let it come down.”*
6	**D**	inference	**He trusts none of his nobles and pays spies in their homes**. Macbeth keeps "a servant fee'd" in every noble's house: he trusts none of them. Lady Macbeth did not even know he had sent to Macduff, so A is wrong. *“There's not a one of them but in his house I keep a servant fee'd.”*
7	**C**	close	**Banquo lies in a ditch with twenty gashes on his head**. The murderer reports Banquo "in a ditch" with "twenty trenched gashes on his head"; the ghost's "gory locks" match, and Macbeth later speaks of "twenty mortal murders on their crowns." *“Safe in a ditch he bides, With twenty trenched gashes on his head; The least a death to nature.” … “Thou canst not say I did it. Never shake Thy gory locks at me.” … “With twenty mortal murders on their crowns,”*
8	2 pts	written	**Prompt.** Reread Macbeth's words to the murderers below. What remark is he answering, and what does he challenge the murderers to prove? Support your answer with one detail from Scene 1. “Ay, in the catalogue ye go for men; As hounds, and greyhounds, mongrels, spaniels, curs,” **Model answer.** Macbeth is answering the First Murderer's protest, "We are men, my liege," after he asks whether they will let Banquo's wrongs go. He replies that all dogs share one name but differ in worth; in the same way, being called men proves nothing. He challenges them to show they have "a station in the file, Not i' th' worst rank of manhood" by killing Banquo. Stung, the murderers answer that they are reckless enough to do anything to spite the world. **2**: Explains that Macbeth says the name "men" proves nothing, just as all dogs are called dogs, and challenges them to prove their worth by killing Banquo, AND gives a specific Scene 1 detail: the First Murderer's "We are men, my liege," the "worst rank of manhood" challenge, or the murderers' replies about being reckless or weary of the world. **1**: Says he insults or flatters them into the murder without explaining the dog comparison, OR explains it with no specific detail from the scene. **0**: Misreads the passage (for example, says he is describing his hunting dogs or praising the murderers) or does not address it. *“We are men, my liege.” … “Now, if you have a station in the file, Not i' th' worst rank of manhood, say't;” … “I am one, my liege, Whom the vile blows and buffets of the world Hath so incens'd that I am reckless what I do to spite the world.”*

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Act 4 · answer key (10 points)

#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
CP	**monkey**	checkpoint	**Which animal does Lady Macduff affectionately call her son while he argues with her about traitors and liars?** One word, found word for word in the text; accept any spelling that is clearly the same word. *“LADY MACDUFF. Now, God help thee, poor monkey!”*
1	**A**	recall	**To hear the answers from the witches or from their masters**. The First Witch asks whether he would rather hear it "from our mouths, Or from our masters"; Macbeth answers "Call 'em," and the apparitions rise. *“Say, if thou'dst rather hear it from our mouths, Or from our masters?” … “Call 'em, let me see 'em.”*
2	**C**	inference	**In this world doing harm is often praised and doing good is dangerous**. She realizes that in this world harm is "often laudable" and good "dangerous folly," so innocence will not protect her. The messenger gives no warrant, and Ross never says the king suspects her. *“I have done no harm. But I remember now I am in this earthly world, where to do harm Is often laudable; to do good sometime Accounted dangerous folly:”*
3	**B**	close	**The apparition calling his name three times**. The bloody child calls "Macbeth! Macbeth! Macbeth!" and Macbeth answers that he would listen with three ears if he had them. Lennox enters only after the witches vanish. *“Macbeth! Macbeth! Macbeth! MACBETH. Had I three ears, I'd hear thee.”*
4	**D**	recall	**A glass that shows many more kings**. The stage direction and Macbeth both say the eighth king bears a glass (a mirror) showing many more of Banquo's line. *“the last with a glass in his hand; Banquo following.” … “And yet the eighth appears, who bears a glass Which shows me many more;”*
5	**A**	inference	**He will accept a flawed king to free Scotland from Macbeth**. Macduff excuses both vices ("fear not yet To take upon you what is yours," "All these are portable") because any lawful king is better than the tyrant; only when Malcolm denies having any virtue does he despair. He does not see through the test, since his despair is real. *“But fear not yet To take upon you what is yours:” … “yet do not fear; Scotland hath foisons to fill up your will, Of your mere own. All these are portable, With other graces weigh'd.”*
6	**B**	recall	**He cures a disease called "the evil" by his touch**. The Doctor says the sick recover "at his touch," and Malcolm names the disease "the evil"; the holy English king is a contrast to Macbeth. *“but at his touch, Such sanctity hath heaven given his hand, They presently amend.” … “'Tis call'd the evil:”*
7	**A**	close	**That the boy's father is a traitor**. The murderer calls Macduff "a traitor" and the boy flies at him. He let his mother call his father a traitor in jest, but defends him against the murderer, and is killed for it. *“Where is your husband?” … “He's a traitor.” … “Thou liest, thou shag-ear'd villain!”*

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#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
8	2 pts	written	**Prompt.** Reread Lady Macduff's words below. What is she saying about her husband's flight, and how does Ross answer her charge? Support your answer with one detail from Scene 2. “for the poor wren, The most diminutive of birds, will fight, Her young ones in her nest, against the owl.” **Model answer.** Lady Macduff says that even the tiny wren fights the owl to protect her young, yet her husband has fled and left his family; he "wants the natural touch" and acted from fear, not love. Ross defends Macduff: she cannot know "whether it was his wisdom or his fear," and her husband is "noble, wise, judicious" and understands "the fits o' th' season." He hints that the times are so cruel that men are called traitors without knowing why, but dares not say more. **2**: Explains the wren comparison (even the smallest bird defends its young, so Macduff's flight shows a lack of natural love or courage) AND gives Ross's answer with a specific detail: "wisdom or his fear," "noble, wise, judicious," "best knows the fits o' th' season," or "cruel are the times, when we are traitors." **1**: Explains the wren comparison but does not give Ross's answer, OR says only in general terms that Ross defends Macduff. **0**: Misreads the passage (for example, says she praises her husband's courage) or does not address it. *“He loves us not: He wants the natural touch;” … “You know not Whether it was his wisdom or his fear.” … “but, for your husband, He is noble, wise, judicious, and best knows The fits o' th' season.” … “But cruel are the times, when we are traitors, And do not know ourselves;”*

Act 5 · answer key (10 points)

#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
CP	**rhubarb**	checkpoint	**Which plant, named alongside senna, does Macbeth wish for as a purgative drug that would scour the English out of Scotland?** One word, found word for word in the text; accept any spelling that is clearly the same word. *“What rhubarb, senna, or what purgative drug, Would scour these English hence?”*
1	**A**	recall	**Write on a paper, seal it, and go back to bed**. The Gentlewoman describes Lady Macbeth taking out paper, writing, reading, and sealing it, all while fast asleep. *“I have seen her rise from her bed, throw her nightgown upon her, unlock her closet, take forth paper, fold it, write upon't, read it, afterwards seal it, and again return to bed; yet all this while in a most fast sleep.”*
2	**C**	inference	**Without a witness to back her, repeating such words is dangerous**. She will tell no one because she has "no witness to confirm" her words: repeating such accusations about the queen without proof could cost her dearly. Her later "She has spoke what she should not" shows she understands the words. *“That, sir, which I will not report after her.” … “Neither to you nor anyone; having no witness to confirm my speech.”*
3	**D**	close	**The English forces he wants scoured out**. Having spoken of his wife, Macbeth turns the medical talk to his kingdom and at once asks what purgative "Would scour these English hence": the disease is the invading army. Famine is something he wishes on the besiegers in Scene 5, not a disease of his land. *“What rhubarb, senna, or what purgative drug, Would scour these English hence?” … “If thou couldst, doctor, cast The water of my land, find her disease, And purge it to a sound and pristine health,”*
4	**C**	recall	**Donalbain**. Caithness asks whether Donalbain is with his brother, and Lennox answers, "For certain, sir, he is not." Menteith and Caithness are marching with Lennox; Fleance is not mentioned. *“Who knows if Donalbain be with his brother? LENNOX. For certain, sir, he is not.”*

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#	Key	Skill	Why, and where the text says it
5	**A**	close	**While enemies live, his sword does better on them**. Macbeth rejects a Roman suicide because "whiles I see lives, the gashes Do better upon them": as long as enemies live, he would rather wound them than himself. *“Why should I play the Roman fool, and die On mine own sword? whiles I see lives, the gashes Do better upon them.”*
6	**D**	inference	**He is restless and cannot settle on what he wants**. He demands his armor before it is needed, has it put on, orders part of it pulled off, then has it carried after him: his outward confidence hides agitation. He plans to wait out a siege, not to charge or flee. *“Give me my armour. SEYTON. 'Tis not needed yet. MACBETH. I'll put it on.” … “Come, put mine armour on; give me my staff:” … “Pull't off, I say.” … “Bring it after me.”*
7	**B**	recall	**His son had his wounds on the front**. Wounds on the front mean young Siward died facing the enemy, not fleeing, so his father calls him "God's soldier." *“Had he his hurts before?” … “Ay, on the front.” … “Why then, God's soldier be he!”*
8	2 pts	written	**Prompt.** Reread Angus's image below. What does it suggest about Macbeth as king? Support your answer with the other image of clothing that a Scottish lord uses for Macbeth earlier in Scene 2. “now does he feel his title Hang loose about him, like a giant's robe Upon a dwarfish thief.” **Model answer.** Angus pictures the crown as a giant's robe stolen by a dwarf: the title is too big for Macbeth, does not fit him, and was never his to wear. He holds it by theft and is too small a man for it. Just before, Caithness uses another clothing image: Macbeth "cannot buckle his distemper'd cause Within the belt of rule," meaning his disordered, sick cause can no longer be held in by lawful government. **2**: Explains that the title does not fit Macbeth because he stole it and is unworthy of it, AND cites Caithness's belt image (he "cannot buckle his distemper'd cause Within the belt of rule") or clearly paraphrases it. **1**: Explains the robe image (stolen or ill-fitting title) but gives no second clothing image, or gives a different detail from the scene instead. **0**: Misreads the image (for example, says Macbeth is growing into his role or is a giant among men) or does not address it. *“He cannot buckle his distemper'd cause Within the belt of rule.” … “now does he feel his title Hang loose about him, like a giant's robe Upon a dwarfish thief.”*

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